

The 2026 GLP-1 Cost Guide

What weight-loss medications really cost —
and the lower-cost ways to access them.



Semaglutide · Tirzepatide · Brand vs. compounded

An independent guide by GLP Guideline · glpguideline.com

START HERE

Why GLP-1 prices are all over the map

GLP-1 medications like semaglutide and tirzepatide are among the most effective tools available for weight management. But what people pay for them ranges from under \$100 to more than \$1,300 a month — often for the same active ingredient.

The price you pay comes down to three things: **which product** you use (brand-name vs. compounded), **whether insurance covers it**, and **how you access it** (pharmacy counter vs. manufacturer self-pay vs. online telehealth). This guide lays out the real 2026 numbers and the routes people use to pay far less.

1 Which product

Brand-name vs. compounded — same active ingredient, very different price.

2 Insurance

Covered, excluded, or prior-authorization only. Changes everything.

3 Access route

Pharmacy counter, manufacturer self-pay, or online telehealth.

"Same drug, up to a 10x price difference."

The active ingredient in a \$1,300 brand-name injection can be the same one in a compounded program costing under \$150. The rest of this guide is about why — and how to land on the cheaper side of that gap.

10x

How to use this guide

This is educational information, not medical advice. Prices change often and vary by dose, provider, and plan. Only a licensed clinician can determine whether any GLP-1 treatment is appropriate for you.

Compounded GLP-1 care is handled through a fully online, clinician-reviewed visit — no pharmacy counter, no insurance required.



THE NUMBERS

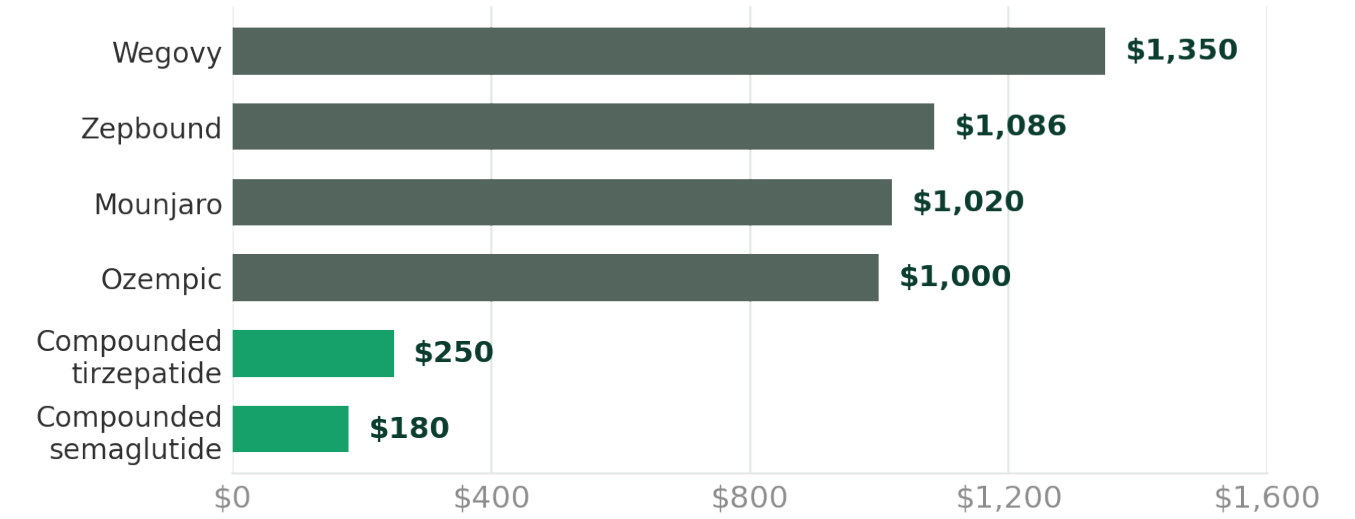
What GLP-1s actually cost in 2026

Same medicine, very different prices. The two compounded rows (highlighted) are the lower-cost route most online programs use.

Medication	What it is	Typical cash price / month
Wegovy	Brand semaglutide, FDA-approved for weight loss	List ~\$1,350; self-pay ~\$349 (intro near \$199)
Zepbound	Brand tirzepatide, FDA-approved for weight loss	List ~\$1,086; self-pay vials \$299–\$449
Ozempic	Brand semaglutide, approved for type 2 diabetes	~\$1,000 (little cash discount)
Mounjaro	Brand tirzepatide, approved for type 2 diabetes	~\$1,020 (little cash discount)
Compounded semaglutide	Made by a licensed U.S. compounding pharmacy*	~\$90–\$270 (varies by dose)
Compounded tirzepatide	Made by a licensed U.S. compounding pharmacy*	~\$150–\$350 (varies by dose)

*Compounded medications are prepared by licensed U.S. pharmacies but are **not FDA-approved**. Figures are typical 2026 ranges and change frequently; your final cost depends on the provider, dose, and plan length.

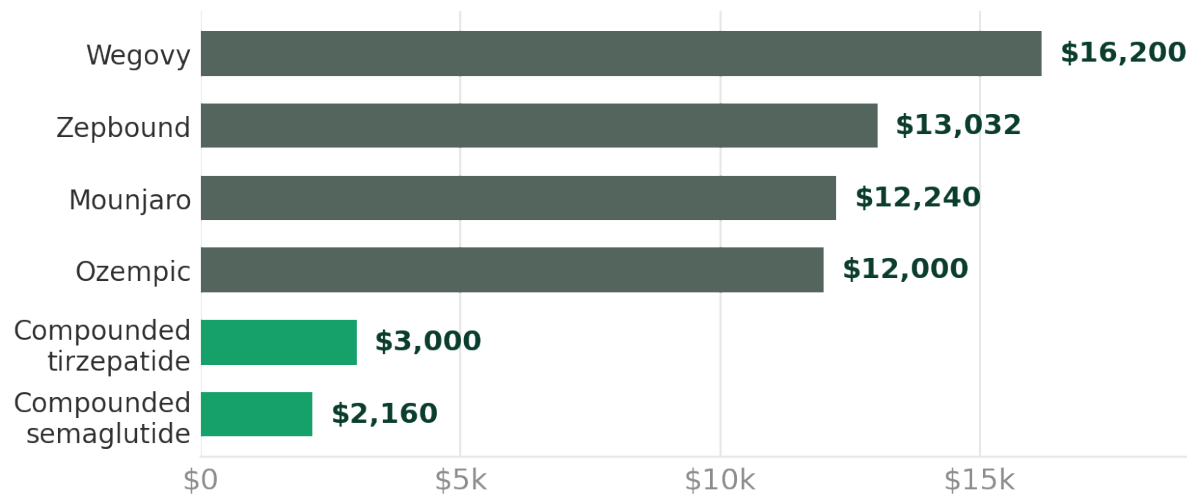
Typical monthly price at a glance



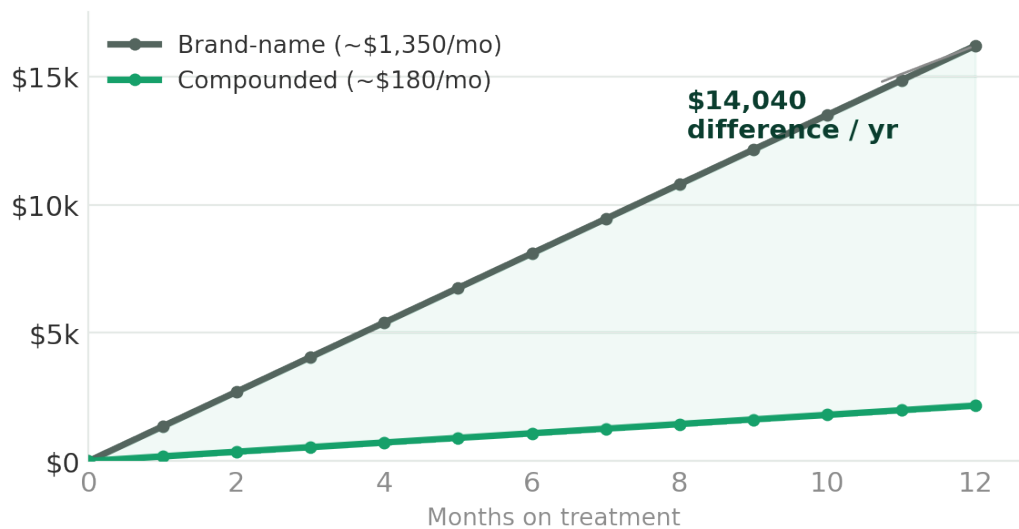
The gap adds up fast over a year

A few hundred dollars a month is one thing. Across a full year of treatment, the difference between brand-name and compounded GLP-1s can run past \$14,000.

Estimated cost per year



What you'd spend over 12 months



Illustrative estimates using typical monthly prices (brand ~\$1,350, compounded ~\$180). Actual cost depends on dose, provider, and plan length.

YOUR OPTIONS

Three ways to get a GLP-1 — and what each costs

1. Through insurance

The cheapest option *if* you're covered — often a \$25–\$100 copay. The catch: many plans exclude weight-loss medications entirely, and those that cover them usually require prior authorization and a documented BMI or condition. Worth checking first, but coverage is far from guaranteed.

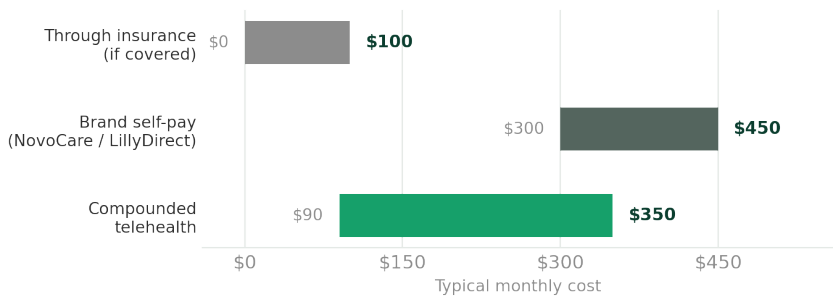
2. Manufacturer self-pay programs

Brand-name medication paid out of pocket at a discount: Wegovy through NovoCare runs about \$349/month, and Zepbound vials through LillyDirect are roughly \$299–\$449/month. You get the exact FDA-approved product, but it's still the priciest of the cash routes.

3. Compounded medication via telehealth

Licensed U.S. compounding pharmacies prepare semaglutide and tirzepatide, prescribed through a fully online visit — typically \$90–\$350/month. It's the lowest-cost and most accessible path, which is why most online programs use it. The trade-off: compounded versions are not FDA-approved, and a licensed clinician must review your history first.

Typical monthly cost by route



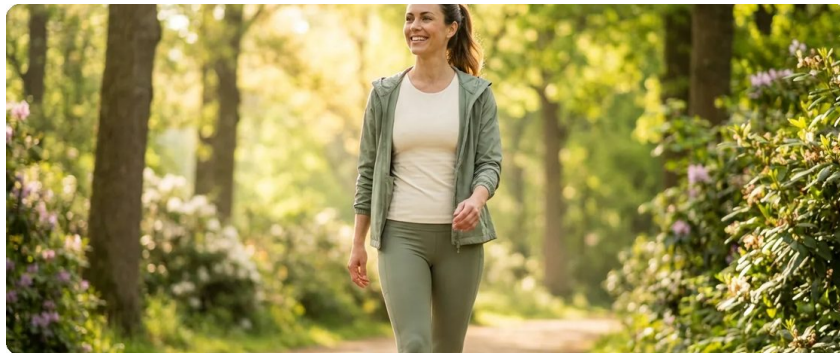
SAVE MONEY

7 ways to lower what you pay

- **Check insurance first.** Ask specifically whether Wegovy or Zepbound is covered, and what the prior-authorization requirements are.
- **Use the manufacturer programs.** NovoCare (Wegovy) and LillyDirect (Zepbound) offer self-pay pricing well below list.
- **Consider compounded options** through a licensed telehealth provider — usually the lowest monthly cost.
- **Ask about flat-rate pricing.** Some programs charge the same price at every dose; others raise the price as your dose increases.
- **Watch for membership fees** stacked on top of the medication cost — the headline price isn't always the full price.
- **Buy in longer plans.** Quarterly or annual plans usually lower the effective per-month cost.
- **Don't pay for promised results.** No legitimate provider can guarantee weight loss — be skeptical of anyone who does.

Red flags — walk away if you see these

- No licensed clinician involved, or a prescription with no real medical review
- Guarantees of a specific amount of weight loss
- No clear safety information or refund/cancellation terms
- Pressure to buy a large supply up front, or hidden fees on top of the price



THE BOTTOM LINE

Is a compounded GLP-1 right for you?

For many people, a compounded semaglutide or tirzepatide program through a licensed telehealth provider is the most affordable and convenient way to access GLP-1 care — often a fraction of brand-name pricing, with no insurance required and everything handled online.

It isn't right for everyone. Compounded medications are not FDA-approved, and eligibility is decided by a licensed clinician based on your health history.

Quick questions, answered

Do I need insurance?

No. Compounded telehealth programs are self-pay and don't require insurance.

Is a prescription required?

Yes. A licensed clinician reviews your information and prescribes only if it's appropriate for you.

How fast does it ship?

If you're prescribed treatment, medication ships discreetly from a licensed U.S. pharmacy, usually within a few days.



See if you qualify in a few minutes

Take the quick eligibility check at glpguideline.com — no commitment, and a licensed clinician reviews every assessment.

Required safety notice. Compounded GLP-1 medications are prepared by licensed U.S. pharmacies and regulated by state boards of pharmacy, but are not evaluated or approved by the FDA. GLP-1 medications may carry risks, including thyroid C-cell tumors. Seek immediate care for symptoms such as neck swelling, hoarseness, trouble swallowing, or shortness of breath. Individual results vary and are not guaranteed.

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